CHAPTER 10 · DEEP DIVE · A HOUSE DIVIDED

# The Birth of Jim Crow

How “Redemption” turned the promises of Reconstruction into a system of legal segregation and disenfranchisement. 1877–1900s.

**Name:** _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

*How “Redemption” turned the promises of Reconstruction into a system of legal segregation and disenfranchisement. 1877–1900s.*

How does a nation go from writing equality into its Constitution to building a system of legal inequality — in just one generation?

## The Old Order Returns

**“REDEMPTION”**

With federal troops gone after 1877, white Democrats — who called themselves “Redeemers” — took full control of every Southern state. They set out to undo Reconstruction and rebuild white supremacy, now dressed in the language of law.

The Reconstruction Amendments were still in the Constitution. But the Redeemers found ways to hollow them out — turning rights on paper into a lived system of inequality called Jim Crow.

## “This Is a White Man's Government”

**THOMAS NAST, 1868**

*Nast had warned years earlier of the coalition — ex-Confederates and their allies — standing on the back of a Black Union veteran. By the 1880s and 1890s, that vision had become law across the South.*

*“This Is a White Man's Government” — wood engraving by Thomas Nast, Harper's Weekly, 1868, public domain (Library of Congress).*

## Disenfranchisement

**TAKING THE VOTE**

First, the Redeemers took back the vote. Remember the loophole in the Fifteenth Amendment? It banned denying the vote by race — so they used tools that never mentioned race: poll taxes (you had to pay to vote), literacy tests (rigged by white officials), and grandfather clauses (you could skip the tests only if your grandfather had voted — which no formerly enslaved person's had).

The effect was staggering: Black voter registration in some states fell by more than 90%. The ballot that the Fifteenth Amendment had promised was all but gone.

*Redemption, 1869–77 — map, © ShadowDog Digital Studios (SDS Digital Collection).*

## Segregation Becomes Law

SEPARATE AND UNEQUAL

Second, the Redeemers built segregation. Laws separated Black and white Americans in schools, trains, restaurants, parks — nearly everything. In Plessy v. Ferguson (1896), the Supreme Court blessed it with the doctrine of “separate but equal.” The facilities were separate; they were almost never equal.

This was the change: in a single generation, the South had gone from Black senators and voters to a rigid caste system enforced by law and by terror.

JUSTICE JOHN MARSHALL HARLAN, DISSENTING IN PLESSY · 1896

Our Constitution is color-blind … The thin disguise of ‘equal’ accommodations … will not mislead any one.

— JUSTICE JOHN MARSHALL HARLAN (THE LONE DISSENTER)

## Measure the Change

YOUR TURN

*You'll compare Reconstruction's high point with the Jim Crow system that replaced it, and practice change over time — naming exactly what was lost, and how.*